

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

Mpala Research Centre & Wildlife Foundation_Kenya_2024-25_3-month Report

Fellowship Organization

Mpala Research Centre & Wildlife Foundation

Fellowship City

Nanyuki

Fellowship Country

Kenya

Fellowship Start Date

08/26/2024

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

08/22/2025

What is your fellowship title/role?

Communications and Community Outreach Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

- Work with Executive Director to develop communications strategy and digital content to amplify Mpala's mission
- Collaborate with researchers and stakeholders to assess impact and disseminate findings to the broader community
- Coordinate partnerships and community programming; enhancing access to conservation science and education for Kenyan students

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Somewhat

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

The logistics and guest relations manager set out an itinerary for me to orient myself at Mpala but most of my supervisors were away when I first arrived.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?

Describe a representative day at work.

I start my days at 8:30am and end at 4:30pm. Most days, I am in the office, brainstorming social media content or coordinating contacts and content for our newsletters. Sometimes, when there are research groups around, I join them in the field to document the work they are doing to be shared on our various platforms. I also help coordinate and organize upcoming events and design promotional materials as required.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

1. To celebrate World Migratory Bird Day, I helped coordinate a full-day event for researchers and staff to go on an excursion to identify and track birds around campus. In line with one of my goals to improve internal culture and communications, this activity that brought together a range of staff to support Mpala's mission of wildlife conservation. At the end of the day, Mpala was ranked #1 for checklist leaders in Kenya!
2. I installed a "Wildlife Sightings" whiteboard and notice/bulletin board in the dining area of Mpala, which has garnered a lot of engagement and interaction. Part of my objective with improving internal communication is to enhance inclusivity. Not only has using the bulletin board made information more accessible to staff who may not use email, but the whiteboard has enabled interactions and engagement between students, staff, and researchers.

What is your organization's work culture like?

What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

I have my own office within the admin building at Mpala. There are about 20 people in this building and a total of over 260 staff at Mpala including the maintenance, infrastructure, and security teams.

To whom do you report?

I have weekly meetings with my supervisor who is based at Princeton. She reviews my social media calendar and newsletter drafts and provides feedback on tasks mostly related to external communications.

I also report to the Chief Operations Officer of Mpala. She is my on-the-ground supervisor who will assign tasks as needed and review work that is more relevant to Mpala Research Centre operations.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

1. Improve internal communications and company culture alignment
2. Continutaion and improvement of social media channels
3. Enhance Mpala's brand recognition and website design
4. Create reports and adhere to deadlines
5. Support community outreach—re-establish Daraja partnership and bring Kenyatta University students to Mpala

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I travelled to Kenyatta University to attend the Climate-U Network Conference. I proposed attending this conference as there were themes related to climate policy and communication.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

My role has a lot of flexibility, and I feel like my workplace had taken good advantage of the skillset and strengths that I bring to the table.

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I booked a flight via Skyscanner from Hong Kong through Mumbai to Nairobi. I took Cathay Pacific from Hong Kong to Mumbai then Kenya Airways from Mumbai to Nairobi. In total, this one-way flight cost \$630.97 USD, which I paid for out of pocket. I then took a private vehicle from Nairobi to Mpala, which took ~5 hours and was arranged and covered by Mpala.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

Internship Pass

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

I am still waiting

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

No

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

\$35 for the eTA to enter Kenya, \$50 to first extend my visa, then another \$100 to apply for the internship pass

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

I am awaiting reimbursement from Mpala as per my contract

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

Yes

If yes, please explain further

A lot of waiting and lack of response

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Start early

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I already had most of my vaccinations done from prior travel, but I also had to get my second Hepatitis A shot, malaria pills and complete my yellow fever vaccination. I got half my malaria pills from UNC's campus clinic, which cost ~\$180, and the rest + yellow fever vaccine from a travel clinic in Hong Kong, which totaled to ~ 4605 HKD (~\$591 USD)

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

I had a great first week in my host country. Since I was one of the later fellows to arrive, it was nice to be able to meet the others in Nairobi.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Housing is provided by Mpala. I live in an ensuite banda on campus.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Very Rural

Please describe your living environment

I live in the bush, in a very remote environment. There are electric wires to fence off large wildlife from entering the centre, but outside of that you get to see pretty much any major African wildlife!

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

It takes me less than 2 minutes to walk from my banda to the dining area and my office. Everything I need is within a very close distance.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

The closest town is Nanyuki, which is around a 1 hour and 15 minute drive away from Mpala. It is a bit inconvenient to get there, but the options are to take the staff bus that leaves 4:30pm each weekday or pay \$40 USD for a private ride as I do not own a vehicle.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

I am presently in the rainy season, but it is mostly warm during the day and cooler at night.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

I wear pretty casual clothing, mostly jeans and a tshirt or athletic clothes and hiking boots if I am doing fieldwork.

How have you been spending your free time?

I often go on game drives with other researchers and staff at Mpala which is very enjoyable. I've visited neighbouring communities such as Lekiji and Koiya through my work, and will sometimes go into Nanyuki town on the weekends.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

I have moved a lot in my life so have experience navigating life both abroad and back home. I am lucky to have found a lot of great community here at Mpala.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I live in a very safe area, the main concern would be wildlife encounters.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

Don't wear earphones when going on walks/runs, walk around at night in pairs, notify people when I'm leaving the center.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

N/A

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

N/A

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I have been working towards these goals since starting my fellowship. Namely, I have been writing and reflecting, learning Swahili, and building relationships with local people. The second goals go hand in hand, and I am grateful for the friendly community that is built around Mpala.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

The main challenge is being able to leave the center flexibly to explore other parts of the country. Because I'm the only fellow at my placement, most of the travelling I do, even if just to meet up with the other fellows, is solo. It costs a lot to hire a private vehicle (\$180 to get from Mpala to Nairobi), so I've been trying to take public transportation, which can sometimes be challenging. I've faced a bit of harassment when navigating the city, mostly microaggressions due to my race.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

N/A

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

The main culture shock is appearing as an obvious foreigner and dealing with the comments and looks associated with that. I try to remember that people's comments about my race may not be intentionally harmful and just "funny" for them.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

How much I've learned about wildlife conservation! As someone who came into this placement without much background in the type of work that's done at Mpala, it's been amazing to reflect back on how much I've learned since being here. The individuals at this centre are all incredibly knowledgeable and I love being able to learn from them.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

The most challenging part would be what I mentioned earlier about getting around and not having the flexibility to leave the center whenever I want to.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

1. Spicy food/options to eat different cuisines
2. My freedom and safety to navigate a place comfortably and conveniently
3. Diversity of activities on weekends

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

1. The nature! The environment here is unbelievably beautiful
2. The fact that I get to live alongside wildlife
3. The range of outdoor activity/adventure spots in Kenya.

How is your stipend being paid?

I get paid monthly via PayPal.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

PayPal

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

N/A

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$8.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$100.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$100.00	\$0.00	\$50.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$150.00	\$0.00	\$50.00	0.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

Especially as someone who is quite removed from the rest of the fellows geographically, I would have appreciate an in-person orientation to interact with the other fellows and have that support system before going our separate ways for the yearlong-fellowship.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

I would have enjoyed hearing more from recent ('23-'24) fellows, but other than that I think most topics were adequately addressed.

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office? What could we improve?

I find it very frustrating that I had to learn via conversations with other fellows in Kenya that I am the only one who is not receiving a stipend for my flights. I was under the assumption that everyone was paying for their own transportation, so it was shocking to learn that I was receiving much less support financially. I would have appreciated more transparency from PiAf regarding stipends being drastically different among fellow placements, with more explanation and justification as to why this is the case. Otherwise, it feels like an extremely inequitable system.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

Again, more open conversation about contracts and what PiAf will do to ensure fellowship experiences are more equal among all fellows.